ing workforces, economic stagnation and a burgeoning population of elders.

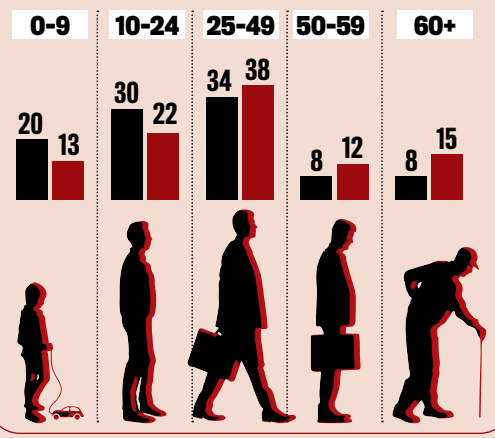
But population experts urge caution against comparing India with developed countries, saying there is no empirical evidence to show that economic progress has slowed due to population stabilisation. On the contrary, a sudden spike could worsen living conditions for many. "We may be talking about making India a trillion-dollar economy, but per capita income remains among the lowest in the world," points out Saswata Ghosh, associate professor, Institute of Development Studies, Kolkata.

Most experts concur that India's "population momentum" will drive continued growth even after reaching replacement-level fertility. "Half of India's population is young and around 30 per cent is at a reproductive age. So, even if we have one or two children per couple, we are going to continue to grow, unlike China and many of the countries. So, the panic is not supported by data or studies," says Poonam Muttreja, executive director, Population Foundation of India.

India's demographic diversity also offers some insulation. While southern states like Kerala and Tamil Nadu grapple with ageing populations and low fertility, northern ones such as Uttar Pradesh and Bihar still have higher fertility rates of 2.7 and 3.0, respectively (see *How the States will Age*). In fact, Prof. Desai believes regional imbalance in fertility allows India to expand the period of demographic dividend and avoid China's demographic cliff with sudden fertility decline and rapid ageing.

HOW THE DEMOGRAPHY WILL CHANGE

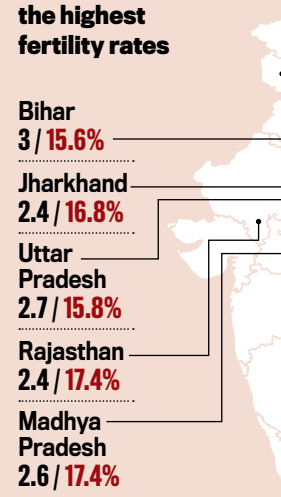
Share of people aged 24 and younger is expected to fall from half of the total population in 2011 to about a third in 2036 while share of sexagenarians almost doubles



Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

HOW THE STATES WILL AGE

Big states with the highest fertility rates



NO CAUSE FOR WORRY

Why India's population isn't at immediate risk despite declining fertility rates

- **31 of 36 Indian states/UTs have achieved replacement-level fertility, signaling population stabilisation**
- **Southern states' advanced fertility transitions offset slow declines in the north, avoiding a demographic cliff like China**
- **Rising living costs and aspirations for quality education/healthcare drive families toward fewer children**
- **Surplus north populations can fill deficits in the south, supported by skill-building and infrastructure**
- **Stabilised fertility eases pressure on land, water, energy, leading to better resource management, long-term ecological balance**

A MATURING DEMOGRAPHIC

So the weight of population numbers isn't about the size or fear of 'extinction', it's about managing the inherent complexities. With a median age of 28, the nation boasts the largest pool of prospective workers in the world. The so-called 'demographic dividend', defined as the economic growth potential from a favourable ratio of working-age individuals to dependants, has fuelled the nation's progress. However, the country is beginning to see signs of demographic maturation (or unemployability), with fewer young people entering the workforce and an ageing population holding ground.

Between 2011 and 2036, the share of the population aged 24 and under is projected to decline from half to just over one-third, while the elderly population—those aged 60 and above—is expected to almost double, to15 per cent. This dual transformation marks the gradual closure of the demographic dividend window. "This window of opportunity will remain for the next 25 years only," warns professor T.V. Sekher of the International Institute for Population Sciences (IIPS).

The Union ministry of health and family welfare-funded Longitudinal Ageing Study in India (LASI), the world's largest survey on ageing, reveals the magnitude of the economic and health burdens that